



Flood Narratives

The Epic of Gilgamesh

WEEK 2 · FRI 25 SEP

WATER QUESTION

What is the most memorable water scene in a story or movie?

Moana, when the ocean parts for her. The water picks who it helps.

ARCHIVING What is here? Facts, ideas, style highlights.

Gilgamesh finds utā-napishti, the one flood survivor, asks how he got eternal life. Gods swear silence; Ea tells a wall (15-22). 'Leave wealth, look for life' (24). Whole city builds the boat: carpenter, thatcher, rich, poor (50-56). Ale for all (75). He loads silver, gold, family, herds, 'experts of all kinds of crafts' (81-86). Storm, gods 'curled up like dogs in the cold' (116). People 'turned to clay' (134). Dove, swallow, crow (147-156). Gods 'swarmed to the sacrifice like flies' (163). Can't stay awake (211), loses the plant to a snake (305-307), shows off Uruk's wall. STYLE: repeats. The mountain 'held on and would not let go', again (142-146).

ANALYZING What does it mean? Who cares, who doesn't, who should care?

It never says WHY the gods send the flood. Belet-ilī blames herself (120), and Ea says 'only the guilty should bear the guilt' (185), so everyone got punished. Who cares: his family and the craftsmen, they're on the boat. Who doesn't: Enlil, angry that anyone lived (175-176). Who should: the city that built the boat. He told them a story about why he was leaving (36-46), and they drowned (134). That bothers me more than the storm does.

EXTENDING How does it relate to other works, our world here and now?

Egan's lakes had nobody deciding. Here a council decides in secret and one god leaks it to one man. Both times regular people do the building and don't get warned. Egan ended on a fishing trip, this ends on a city wall. Floods now: who gets the warning first?

DISCUSSION What helpful questions can we ask about this work?

Why doesn't the story ever say why the gods sent the flood?
Why save the craftsmen but not the people who built the boat?
Is the wall of Uruk an answer to death, or a consolation prize?

VOCABULARY WORDS

Apsu · Anunnaki · sheepfold
cull · slipway · utā-napishti

FEELINGS EVOKED

Wants terror (the storm, the clay),
then pity when he loses the plant.
On me: the city bugged me most.

